

Cambridge International AS & A Level

PHYSICS**9702/21**

Paper 2 AS Level Structured Questions

October/November 2025

MARK SCHEME

Maximum Mark: 60

Published

This mark scheme is published as an aid to teachers and candidates, to indicate the requirements of the examination. It shows the basis on which Examiners were instructed to award marks. It does not indicate the details of the discussions that took place at an Examiners' meeting before marking began, which would have considered the acceptability of alternative answers.

Mark schemes should be read in conjunction with the question paper and the Principal Examiner Report for Teachers.

Cambridge International will not enter into discussions about these mark schemes.

Cambridge International is publishing the mark schemes for the October/November 2025 series for most Cambridge IGCSE, Cambridge International A and AS Level components, and some Cambridge O Level components.

This document consists of **13** printed pages.

Generic Marking Principles

These general marking principles must be applied by all examiners when marking candidate answers. They should be applied alongside the specific content of the mark scheme or generic level descriptions for a question. Each question paper and mark scheme will also comply with these marking principles.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 1:

Marks must be awarded in line with:

- the specific content of the mark scheme or the generic level descriptors for the question
- the specific skills defined in the mark scheme or in the generic level descriptors for the question
- the standard of response required by a candidate as exemplified by the standardisation scripts.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 2:

Marks awarded are always **whole marks** (not half marks, or other fractions).

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 3:

Marks must be awarded **positively**:

- marks are awarded for correct/valid answers, as defined in the mark scheme. However, credit is given for valid answers which go beyond the scope of the syllabus and mark scheme, referring to your Team Leader as appropriate
- marks are awarded when candidates clearly demonstrate what they know and can do
- marks are not deducted for errors
- marks are not deducted for omissions
- answers should only be judged on the quality of spelling, punctuation and grammar when these features are specifically assessed by the question as indicated by the mark scheme. The meaning, however, should be unambiguous.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 4:

Rules must be applied consistently, e.g. in situations where candidates have not followed instructions or in the application of generic level descriptors.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 5:

Marks should be awarded using the full range of marks defined in the mark scheme for the question (however; the use of the full mark range may be limited according to the quality of the candidate responses seen).

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 6:

Marks awarded are based solely on the requirements as defined in the mark scheme. Marks should not be awarded with grade thresholds or grade descriptors in mind.

Science-Specific Marking Principles

- 1 Examiners should consider the context and scientific use of any keywords when awarding marks. Although keywords may be present, marks should not be awarded if the keywords are used incorrectly.
- 2 The examiner should not choose between contradictory statements given in the same question part, and credit should not be awarded for any correct statement that is contradicted within the same question part. Wrong science that is irrelevant to the question should be ignored.
- 3 Although spellings do not have to be correct, spellings of syllabus terms must allow for clear and unambiguous separation from other syllabus terms with which they may be confused (e.g. ethane / ethene, glucagon / glycogen, refraction / reflection).
- 4 The error carried forward (ecf) principle should be applied, where appropriate. If an incorrect answer is subsequently used in a scientifically correct way, the candidate should be awarded these subsequent marking points. Further guidance will be included in the mark scheme where necessary and any exceptions to this general principle will be noted.
- 5 'List rule' guidance
For questions that require ***n*** responses (e.g. State **two** reasons ...):
 - The response should be read as continuous prose, even when numbered answer spaces are provided.
 - Any response marked *ignore* in the mark scheme should not count towards ***n***.
 - Incorrect responses should not be awarded credit but will still count towards ***n***.
 - Read the entire response to check for any responses that contradict those that would otherwise be credited. Credit should **not** be awarded for any responses that are contradicted within the rest of the response. Where two responses contradict one another, this should be treated as a single incorrect response.
 - Non-contradictory responses after the first ***n*** responses may be ignored even if they include incorrect science.

6 Calculation specific guidance

Correct answers to calculations should be given full credit even if there is no working or incorrect working, **unless** the question states 'show your working'.

For questions in which the number of significant figures required is not stated, credit should be awarded for correct answers when rounded by the examiner to the number of significant figures given in the mark scheme. This may not apply to measured values.

For answers given in standard form (e.g. $a \times 10^n$) in which the convention of restricting the value of the coefficient (a) to a value between 1 and 10 is not followed, credit may still be awarded if the answer can be converted to the answer given in the mark scheme.

Unless a separate mark is given for a unit, a missing or incorrect unit will normally mean that the final calculation mark is not awarded. Exceptions to this general principle will be noted in the mark scheme.

7 Guidance for chemical equations

Multiples / fractions of coefficients used in chemical equations are acceptable unless stated otherwise in the mark scheme.

State symbols given in an equation should be ignored unless asked for in the question or stated otherwise in the mark scheme.

Annotations guidance for centres

Examiners use a system of annotations as a shorthand for communicating their marking decisions to one another. Examiners are trained during the standardisation process on how and when to use annotations. The purpose of annotations is to inform the standardisation and monitoring processes and guide the supervising examiners when they are checking the work of examiners within their team. The meaning of annotations and how they are used is specific to each component and is understood by all examiners who mark the component.

We publish annotations in our mark schemes to help centres understand the annotations they may see on copies of scripts. Note that there may not be a direct correlation between the number of annotations on a script and the mark awarded. Similarly, the use of an annotation may not be an indication of the quality of the response.

The annotations listed below were available to examiners marking this component in this series.

Annotations

Annotation	Meaning
	Information missing or insufficient for credit
	Arithmetic error
	Benefit of the doubt given
	Contradiction in response, mark not awarded
	Incorrect point or mark not awarded
	Error carried forward applied
	Ignore the response
	Mandatory mark not awarded
	Power of ten error
	Blank page seen
	Error in number of significant figures

Annotation	Meaning
	Transcription error
	Correct point or mark awarded
	Incorrect physics

Abbreviations

/	Alternative and acceptable answers for the same marking point.
()	Bracketed content indicates words which do not need to be explicitly seen to gain credit but which indicate the context for an answer. The context does not need to be seen but if a context is given that is incorrect then the mark should not be awarded.
—	Underlined content must be present in answer to award the mark. This means either the exact word or another word that has the same technical meaning.

Mark categories

B marks	These are <u>independent</u> marks, which do not depend on other marks. For a B mark to be awarded, the point to which it refers must be seen specifically in the candidate's answer.
M marks	These are <u>mandatory</u> marks upon which A marks later depend. For an M mark to be awarded, the point to which it refers must be seen specifically in the candidate's answer. If a candidate is not awarded an M mark, then the later A mark cannot be awarded either.
C marks	These are <u>compensatory</u> marks which can be awarded even if the points to which they refer are not written down by the candidate, providing subsequent working gives evidence that they must have known them. For example, if an equation carries a C mark and the candidate does not write down the actual equation but does correct working which shows the candidate knew the equation, then the C mark is awarded. If a correct answer is given to a numerical question, all of the preceding C marks are awarded automatically. It is only necessary to consider each of the C marks in turn when the numerical answer is not correct.
A marks	These are <u>answer</u> marks. They may depend on an M mark or allow a C mark to be awarded by implication.

Question	Answer	Marks
1(a)	rate of change of velocity	B1
1(b)(i)	acceleration = $320 / 20$ $= 16 \text{ m s}^{-2}$	A1
1(b)(ii)	$s = \frac{1}{2} ((u) + v)t$ or distance = area under graph	C1
	(height) = $\frac{1}{2} \times 20 \times 320 = 3200 \text{ m}$ or 3.2 km	A1
1(c)(i)	$(\Delta E_P) = mg\Delta h$	C1
	$= 2.9 \times 10^6 \times 9.81 \times 3200$ $= 9.1 \times 10^{10} \text{ J}$	A1
1(c)(ii)	$(\Delta E_K) = \frac{1}{2} m\Delta(v^2)$	C1
	$= \frac{1}{2} \times 2.9 \times 10^6 \times 320^2$ $= 1.5 \times 10^{11} \text{ J}$	A1
1(c)(iii)	(power =) work done / time	C1
	power = $((1.5 + 0.91) \times 10^{11}) / 20$ $= 1.2 \times 10^{10} \text{ W}$	A1

Question	Answer	Marks
2(a)(i)	(normal) force per (unit cross-sectional) area	B1
2(a)(ii)	(due to difference in depth there is a) difference in pressure between top and bottom (of ball)	B1
	(due to pressure difference, upwards) force on bottom of ball is greater (than downwards force on top of ball, so resultant force is upwards)	B1
2(b)(i)	arrow vertically downwards labelled 'weight'	B1
	arrow vertically upwards labelled 'upthrust'	B1
	arrow vertically upwards labelled '(viscous) drag'	B1
2(b)(ii)	SI base units of D : kg m s^{-2}	C1
	base units of η : $\text{kg m s}^{-2} / (\text{m} \times \text{m s}^{-1})$ $= \text{kg m}^{-1} \text{s}^{-1}$	A1
2(c)(i)	$\text{upthrust} = 920 \times (4/3) \times \pi \times (4.2 \times 10^{-3})^3 \times 9.81 = 2.8 \times 10^{-3} \text{ (N)}$	A1
2(c)(ii)	weight = drag + upthrust	C1
	$(2.4 \times 10^{-3} \times 9.81) = (2.8 \times 10^{-3}) + (6\pi \times 4.7 \times 4.2 \times 10^{-3} \times v)$	C1
	$v = 0.056 \text{ m s}^{-1}$	A1

Question	Answer	Marks
3(a)	ratio of stress to strain	B1
3(b)(i)	$R_0 = \rho L / A$	A1
3(b)(ii)	$k = F / x$	C1
	$E = FL / Ax = ((F / x) \times (L / A)) = kL / A$ leading to $k_0 = EA / L$	A1
3(c)(i)	straight line with positive gradient starting at (0, R_0)	B1
3(c)(ii)	straight horizontal line starting at (0, k_0)	B1
3(d)(i)	$L = [0.034 \times \pi \times (0.80 \times 10^{-3})^2] / 1.8 \times 10^{-8} = 3.8 \text{ (m)}$	A1
3(d)(ii)	$k = [1.3 \times 10^{11} \times \pi \times (0.80 \times 10^{-3})^2] / 3.8$ or $k = EA / [RA / \rho] = E\rho / R$ $= [1.3 \times 10^{11} \times 1.8 \times 10^{-8}] / 0.034$	C1
	$k = 6.9 \times 10^4 \text{ N m}^{-1}$	A1

Question	Answer	Marks
4(a)	wave passing through gap / aperture	B1
	(wave) spreads (out)	B1
4(b)(i)	$n\lambda = d \sin \theta$	C1
	$\theta = \sin^{-1} [(540 \times 10^{-9}) / (5.0 \times 10^{-6})] = 6.2^\circ$	A1
4(b)(ii)	$\theta = 12^\circ$	A1
4(b)(iii)	peaks / maxima shown at $\theta = 0, \pm 6^\circ$ and $\pm 12^\circ$	B1
	peaks / maxima and zero intensity in between	B1
	central peak / maxima at intensity I_0 and the other peaks all equal to or less than I_0	B1
4(c)	peaks / maxima all at the same angles (as before)	B1
	intensity (of all peaks / maxima) halved	B1

Question	Answer	Marks
5(a)	<u>sum of</u> current(s) into junction = <u>sum of</u> current(s) out junction or (algebraic) sum of current(s) at a junction is zero	B1
5(b)(i)	line with negative gradient	C1
	line from 0 °C to 100 °C, starting at (0, R_0) with negative gradient throughout and never reaching $R = 0$	A1
5(b)(ii)	(resistance of T decreases so) total resistance (of circuit) decreases	B1
	current in cell increases (so p.d. across internal resistance increases)	B1
	terminal p.d. decreases (and resistance of R is constant) so current in R decreases	B1
5(c)(i)	p.d. across $r = 1.50 - (6.00 \times 0.200)$ $(= 0.30 \text{ V})$	C1
	current in cell $= 0.30 / 0.12$ $= 2.5 \text{ A}$	A1
5(c)(ii)	current in thermistor $= 2.5 - 0.200$ $(= 2.3 \text{ A})$	C1
	resistance of T $= (6.00 \times 0.200) / 2.3$ $= 0.52 \Omega$	A1

Question	Answer	Marks
6(a)(i)	numbers of protons and electrons both = 1	A1
	number of neutrons = 2	A1
6(a)(ii)	diagram shows 2 neutrons and 1 proton labelled and forming a nucleus	B1
	diagram shows 1 electron labelled and separated from the nucleus (not touching the proton and neutrons)	B1
6(b)(i)	helium nucleus: top line = 3 and bottom line = 2	A1
	beta particle: top line = 0 and bottom line = –1	A1
6(b)(ii)	(electron) antineutrino	B1
6(c)	proton: up up down or neutron: up down down	C1
	(tritium:) 4 up, 5 down	A1